

GLOBAL ECONOMICS ANALYST

The Path to 2075 — Is Convergence Really Over?

- Do poor economies grow faster than rich economies? Many economists argue that the evidence for convergence between low- and high-income economies is weak, suggesting that generalized convergence was largely confined to the ‘hyper-globalization’ decade of 2000–10. If true, this would be bad news for global well-being, and it would fundamentally weaken a key justification for long-term investment in emerging markets.
- We argue that previous studies that reported only limited evidence of convergence are incomplete, because they fail to weight countries by population size – effectively treating China and Cyprus’s experiences as equally significant. With this simple adjustment, we find that economic convergence has been a consistent feature of the global economy since the 1980s.
- The key drivers of this convergence have been Asia’s most populous nations: China (since the early 1980s), and India, Indonesia and Bangladesh (from the late 1990s onwards). Together, these four countries account for more than 40% of the global population.
- Among developed economies, the US has been an important positive outlier. Despite possessing one of the world’s highest levels of GDP per capita, its GDP per capita growth has continued to outpace most other developed markets.
- The contrast that we find with unweighted convergence studies suggests an intuitive point: periods of rapid globalization, such as 2000–10, are especially beneficial for the development of small economies with limited domestic markets. However, for large emerging market economies – especially those in East Asia – economic convergence appears relatively robust. This ongoing convergence implies that the share of global GDP represented by emerging markets (and East Asian EMs in particular) will continue to rise over time.
- Looking ahead, risks exist in both directions. The development of AI seems likely to bolster the strong performance of the US and parts of East Asia (in particular, China, South Korea and Taiwan). On the downside, increased protectionism could result in a reversal of globalization, while climate change poses a particular risk to Southern Asia and parts of Africa.

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The Path to 2075 — Is Convergence Really Over?

Economic Convergence, Led by Asia's Powerhouses

In this *Global Economics Analyst*, we review the performance of GDP per capita across 121 developed (DM) and emerging market (EM) economies since 1980, with a particular emphasis on the process of long-term economic convergence.

The principle of convergence – that poorer economies generally grow faster than richer economies over time – is a central assumption underpinning our *Path to 2075 projections* for the global economy (see Box 1).¹ The logic is that the marginal return on investment should be higher in poorer economies where capital is relatively scarce, which attracts investment, increases capital stock, and raises living standards.

We begin by outlining some key stylized facts about GDP per capita levels and growth rates across the world. [Exhibit 1](#) (left-hand side) depicts GDP per capita across various regions since 1980, while the right-hand panel presents the same data indexed to 1980. Several features stand out:

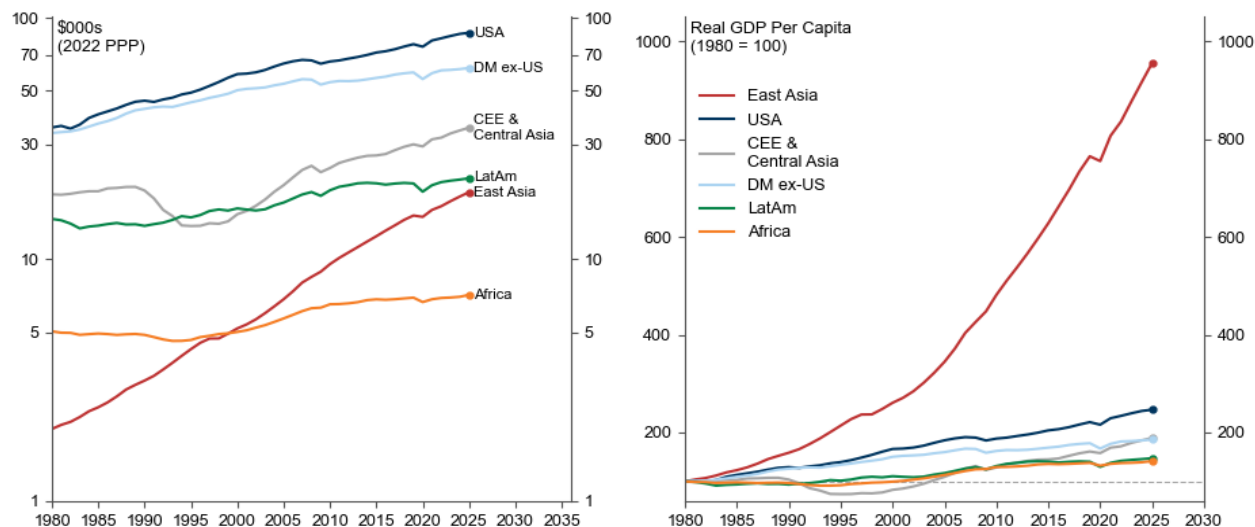
1. Cross-country differences in GDP per capita levels are large, even after adjusting for differences in purchasing power parity.² To take one striking example, GDP per person in the US is more than 12 times higher than the average across Africa.
2. East Asia's emerging markets have seen rapid GDP per capita growth, with average output per person now nearly 10 times higher than in 1980. However, GDP per capita in the region remains well below US and Western European levels, suggesting further potential for convergence.
3. US GDP per capita growth since 1980 has either matched or exceeded GDP per capita growth in the majority of other regions (with East Asia the only exception), despite having a much higher starting level of GDP per capita.
4. GDP per capita growth in Latin American and African economies has disappointed, averaging +0.9% and +0.8% per year respectively since 1980.
5. The break-up of the Soviet Union and the dissolution of the Eastern Bloc was initially very negative for GDP per capita in Eastern Europe and Central Asia in the early 1990s. However, GDP per capita levels have since rebounded in this region.

¹ “[The Path to 2075 — Slower Global Growth, But Convergence Remains Intact](#)”, Goldman Sachs Global Economics Paper, 6 December 2022.

² The choice between PPP weights and market weights depends on the comparison's purpose. PPP weights account for lower prices in poorer economies and better reflect welfare gains, while market weights show the Dollar value of each economy's GDP without adjusting for spending power. Since we are focused on income convergence, we use PPP weights. See “[How Fast Does the World Grow?](#)”, *GS Global Economics Analyst*, 27 October 2021.

Exhibit 1: GDP per Capita in East Asian EMs Has Risen Nearly Tenfold Since 1980, But Remains Well Below DM Levels

LHS: Real GDP Per Capita (\$000s log scale; 2022 PPP); RHS: Real GDP Per Capita (2022 PPP, 1980=100)



Regions are weighted by population size

Source: The Conference Board Total Economy Database™ (April 2026), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

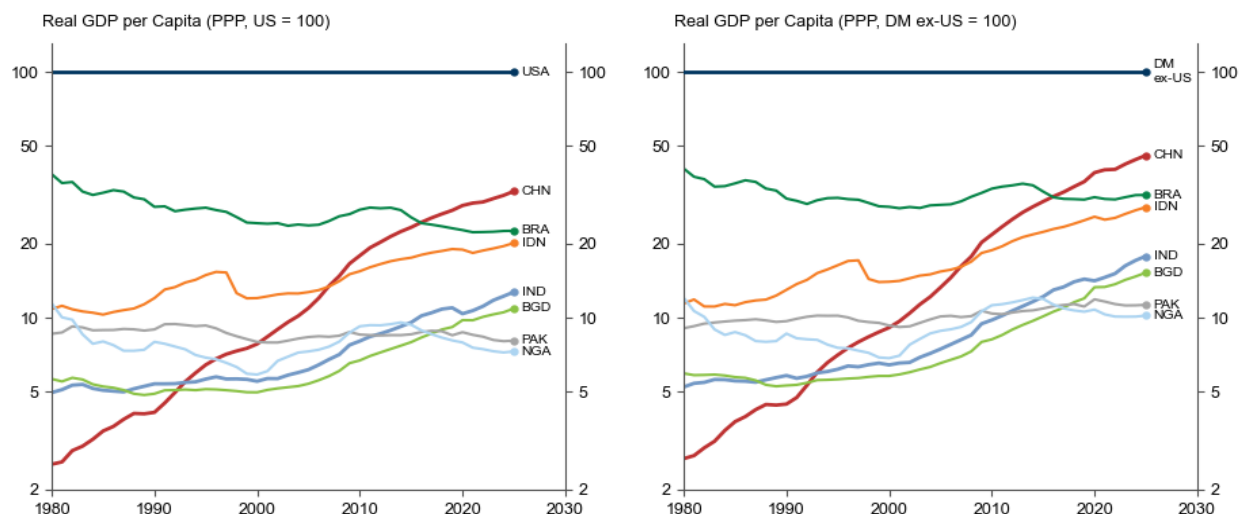
Exhibit 2 compares the GDP per capita of the eight most populous countries. The US is fixed as the 'frontier economy' in the left panel, while developed economies (excluding the US) are set as the benchmark in the right panel. China has seen significant income convergence, rising from just over 2% of US levels in 1980 to around 33% today. Since the late 1990s, India, Indonesia, and Bangladesh have also shown clear progress.

When compared to US GDP per capita, Brazil, Pakistan, and Nigeria have underperformed, with Brazil slipping further behind the US over time, while Pakistan and Nigeria have remained largely unchanged. However, as the US has shown particularly strong performance among developed markets, the relative picture shifts if we compare these economies to developed markets more broadly – Pakistan and Nigeria now show some convergence, whereas Brazil has remained more or less flat.³

³ The aim of this piece is to record, rather than explain, the convergence that has occurred. However, the question remains as to why the GDP per capita performance of Brazil, Pakistan and Nigeria has been disappointing. In Brazil's case, macroeconomic instability, high government spending crowding out private investment, significant trade barriers and inadequate infrastructure are all cited as contributing factors. For Pakistan and Nigeria, macroeconomic instability, elite capture and incomplete property rights are frequently mentioned.

Exhibit 2: China Has Converged Fastest Among the World's Most Populous States, But India, Indonesia and Bangladesh Are Also Converging

Real GDP Per Capita in 2022 PPP, log scale (LHS: US = 100, RHS: DM ex-US=100)



Source: The Conference Board Total Economy Database™ (April 2026), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

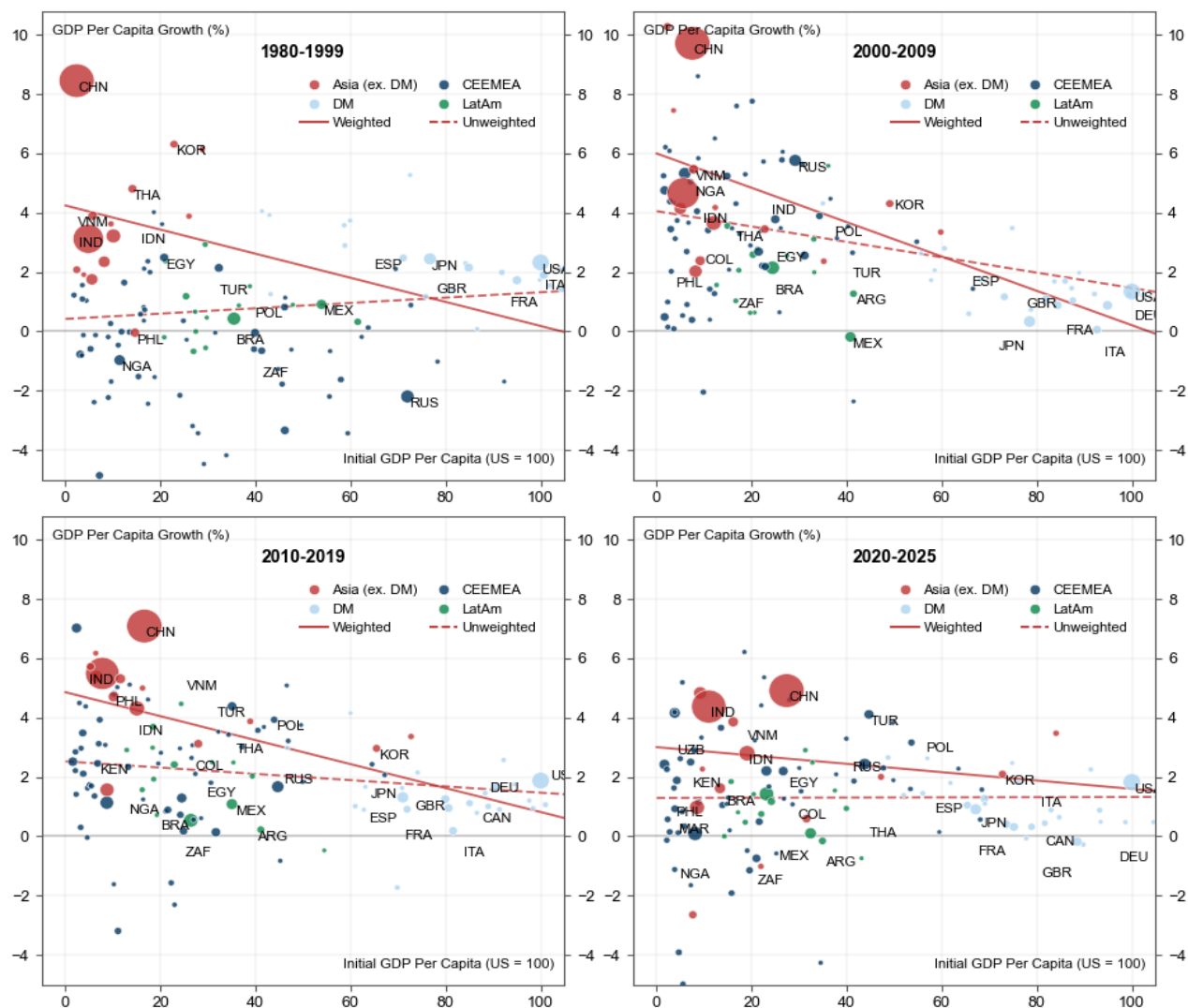
Population-Weighted Convergence is Reasonably Stable Across Decades

Exhibit 3 illustrates average GDP per capita growth in relation to initial GDP per capita levels for EM and DM economies across four distinct periods: 1980-1999, 2000-2009, 2010-2019, and 2020-2025. The level of GDP per capita is shown relative to the US (US = 100). We also show lines of best fit for all 121 economies on both a population-weighted and an unweighted basis.

Across all four periods, the population-weighted regression line slopes downwards, indicating that GDP per capita growth has been higher in low-income economies than in high-income economies (i.e., that there has been convergence). In contrast, the regression lines for unweighted countries are mixed, showing convergence in some periods but not in others. Moreover, the slope of the regression line is steeper for population-weighted countries in all four periods. Note that, although the performance of China and India is central to the narrative of population-weighted convergence – unsurprising given that together they comprise more than a third of the world's population – the regression lines continue to slope downwards from 2000 even when these two countries are excluded.

Exhibit 3: GDP per Capita Has Grown Faster in Low-Income Economies than in High-Income Economies

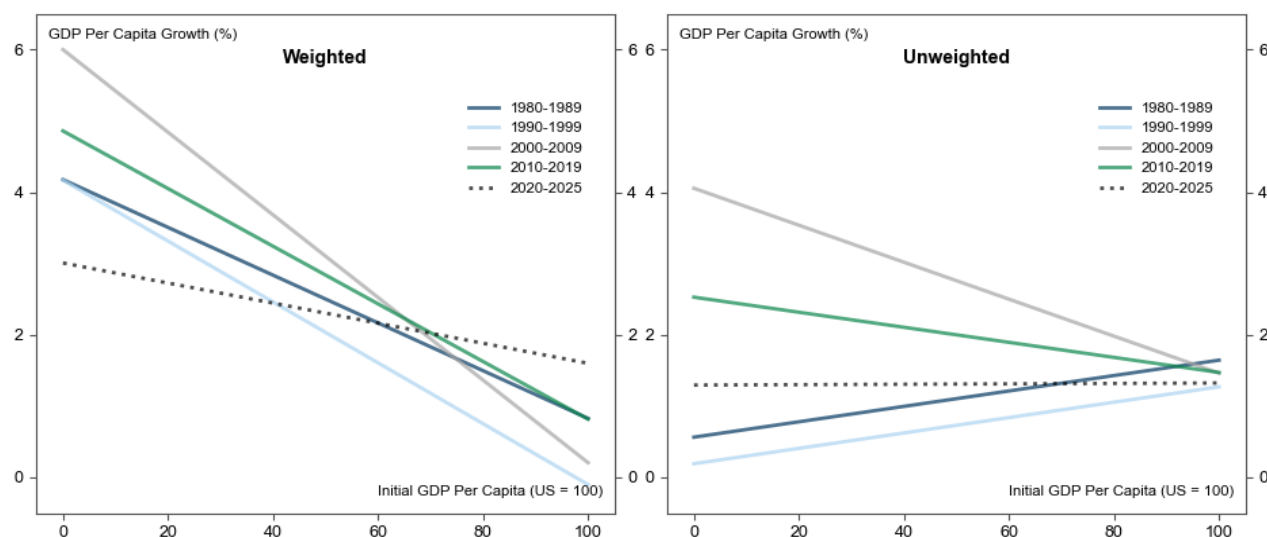
Real GDP Per Capita (PPP, %) vs Initial GDP Per Capita (US=100); Size of bubble = average population size



Source: The Conference Board Total Economy Database™ (April 2026), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4 examines decade-by-decade changes in regression slopes. The population-weighted regressions show broadly similar slopes, except for 2020-2025, where the slope is still downward but less marked. The past half decade has seen a series of major shocks – the pandemic, the 2022 energy crisis, and 2025 US tariffs – and it remains to be seen how the slope will look for the decade as a whole. In comparison with the weighted lines, the regression slopes for countries on an unweighted basis display much greater variability.

Exhibit 4: GDP per Capita Growth Has Been Faster in Low-Income Economies in Every Decade on a Weighted Basis, But the Pattern is More Mixed on an Unweighted Basis
Population weighted vs unweighted fitted lines



Source: The Conference Board Total Economy Database™ (April 2026), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

How rapid is this convergence? Since 2000, individuals in countries with a GDP per capita at 50% of the US level have, on average, experienced GDP per capita growth approximately 2.3pp higher than those in developed economies with productivity levels similar to the US.⁴ Over a 10-year period, GDP per capita levels for such individuals would have risen from 50% of US levels to around 61% of US levels.

How Our Results Compare with the Existing Growth Literature

On one level, our finding that the process of economic convergence is relatively robust and has been a consistent feature since the early 1980s should not be particularly surprising, as it is a central prediction of many economic models.⁵ However, the majority of cross-country studies have found little evidence that poor countries grow faster than rich ones, irrespective of other factors – in other words, there is little evidence of absolute or generalized convergence in the GDP per capita levels of countries over time.⁶

By making the simple adjustment of weighting each country by population size, our results suggest that convergence between poor and rich economies is a more robust feature than implied by previous studies of this type. **If the unit of aggregation is taken to be people, rather than countries – which is what population-weighting achieves – then convergence is alive and well.**

⁴ The slope of the regression line for 2000-2025 is around -0.05.

⁵ Standard (neo-classical) growth theory suggests that relatively poor, low-productivity economies should grow at a faster rate than relatively rich, high-productivity countries. This result follows directly from the assumption of diminishing marginal returns on capital: in developing economies where capital is limited, the returns on capital should be greater than in richer economies where capital is abundant. In turn, the relatively high returns on capital in less developed economies should attract investment, increasing the capital stock and raising living standards.

⁶ A key paper in this literature is Barro and Sala-i-Martin (1992), 'Convergence', *Journal of Political Economy*. Other studies found evidence of 'conditional' convergence – meaning that convergence occurs only when specific factors, such as institutional quality, are present. See Mankiw, Romer and Weil (1992) 'A Contribution to the Empirics of Economic Growth', *Quarterly Journal of Economics*.

We are not the first to adjust for population size in this way. Previous studies have also weighted by population size and, consistent with our findings, have found stronger evidence of convergence on this basis.⁷ Nonetheless, those studies maintain that, when assessing which economic policies drive growth and convergence, it is still reasonable to treat each country as an equal unit, since such policies are largely determined at the national level. We disagree for two reasons: First, economic welfare is a study of people, not nations, and if more people reside in some nations than others, they should be weighted accordingly. Second, a country's size is itself a potentially significant factor influencing growth and convergence. If larger countries tend to grow faster than smaller ones, this may partially be attributable to their size. Overlooking this aspect risks missing a potentially important determinant of growth.⁸

The contrast that we find with unweighted convergence studies suggests an important and intuitive point: periods of rapid globalization, such as 2000–10, tend to be particularly beneficial for the development of small economies with limited domestic markets. However, for large emerging market economies, economic convergence appears to be more resilient to the pace of globalization.

EM Growth Continues to Outstrip DM Growth by a Wide Margin

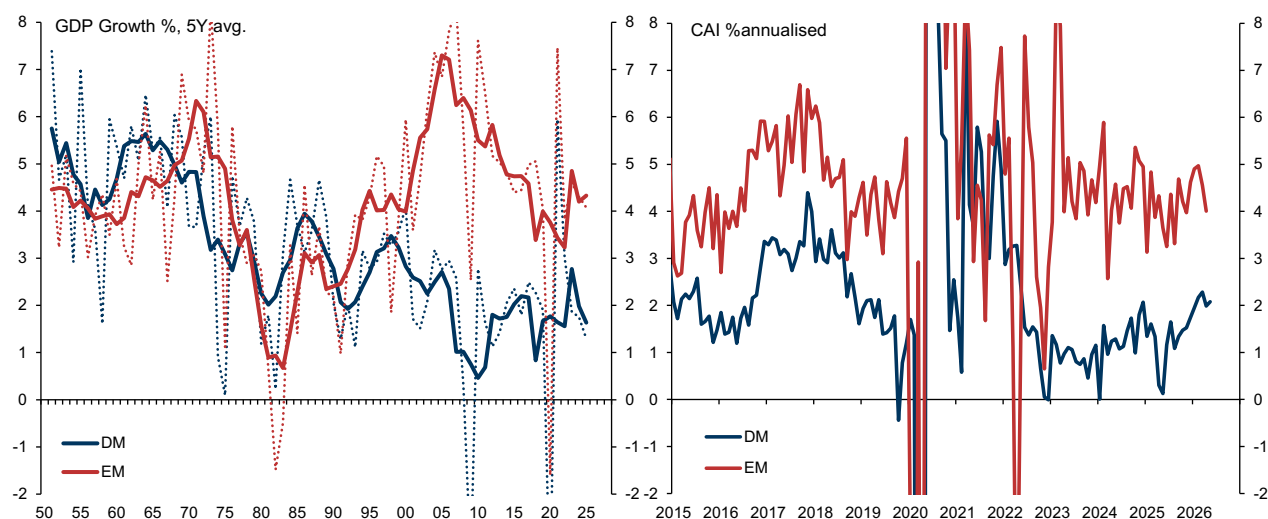
Our findings also explain why EMs consistently outgrow DM countries in our coverage – if convergence were not a fairly consistent feature of the global economy, this would not occur. While population growth is also higher in EMs, it does not fully explain the gap in potential growth rates (4.2% vs 1.6%). Moreover, in the four years since we published our *Path to 2075 long-term economic projections*, the gap between EM and DM growth has so far been larger than we expected (2.6pp vs. 2.0pp).

⁷ In a follow-up paper to Barro and Sala-i-Martin (1992)), Sala-i-Martin (2006) acknowledges that there is stronger evidence of convergence in income distribution at the level of the individual rather than the country but maintains that a country framework makes sense when evaluating which economic policies drive growth and convergence. See Sala-i-Martin (2006), 'The World Distribution of Income: Falling Poverty and... Convergence, Period', *Quarterly Journal of Economics*.

⁸ A large domestic market makes it easier to achieve economies of scale while still focused primarily on domestic demand, especially if industries are protected during their early stages of development. This strategy – protecting fledgling industries until they reach sufficient size – is less likely to succeed in countries with a small domestic market. There is also a related but distinct point concerning economic geography: large economies are able to support bigger cities and benefit from agglomeration effects, and economic convergence is often associated with rising urbanization and increased specialization. This is more difficult to achieve in small economies with small populations.

Exhibit 5: After a Brief Hiatus During the Pandemic, EM Economies Are Outgrowing DM Economies

LHS: GDP Growth (% 5Y avg); RHS: Current Activity Indicator (% change, annualized)



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The ongoing convergence between (population-weighted) poor and rich economies implies that the incomes of EM economies will gradually move closer to those of developed economies – resulting in a further reduction in global income inequality – and that the share of global GDP represented by emerging markets will continue to increase over time.

Looking forward, there are both positive and negative risks to long-term economic growth and convergence. The development of AI seems likely to bolster the strong performance of the US and parts of South-East Asia and lift global GDP productivity growth more generally.⁹ In terms of AI-related capital expenditure, South Korea and Taiwan are already the main beneficiaries, while from a development and adoption standpoint, China seems well-placed to gain.

On the downside, we consider two risks especially significant: First, although global growth and trade have so far been surprisingly resilient to rising tariffs, increased protectionism could still trigger a reversal of globalization. Second, climate change represents a particular threat to Southern Asia and parts of Africa.

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⁹ For a discussion of the potential boost to EM productivity from AI and technology adoption more generally, see “EM Technology Adoption Cycles and Implications for Artificial Intelligence”, *Global Economics Comment*, 21 May 2026.

Box 1: The Path to 2075 — Long-Term Projections for the Global Economy

The Path to 2075 projections builds on our original BRICs analysis, offering long-term forecasts for the global economy, covering 104 countries out to the year 2075.¹⁰ Exhibit 6 provides a high-level summary of our projections for the major regional aggregates, broken down by decade.

Our projections imply that global growth in 2024-29 (2.8%) will be faster than in 2020-24, but slower than in the 2010-19 decade (3.2%, based on market FX weights).¹¹ We project that EM growth will continue to outstrip DM growth (3.8% vs. 1.8%), with around half of this difference due to demographic factors and the other half due to productivity growth differentials. We expect Asia (ex-DM) to remain the fastest-growing region.

Exhibit 6: A Gradual Slowdown in Global Economic Growth, With EM Growth Continuing to Outstrip DM

	Market FX Weighted								
	2000-2009	2010-2019	2020-2029	2024-2029	2030-2039	2040-2049	2050-2059	2060-2069	2070-2079
World	2.7	3.2	2.4	2.8	2.5	2.1	2.0	1.8	1.7
DM	1.6	1.9	1.5	1.8	1.6	1.4	1.3	1.2	1.1
EM	5.7	5.1	3.6	3.8	3.2	2.6	2.3	2.1	1.9
Asia (ex. DM)	7.6	6.7	4.1	4.2	3.1	2.4	2.1	1.8	1.5
CEEMEA	4.8	3.5	2.6	3.2	3.3	3.1	3.0	2.9	2.7
LatAm	2.8	2.4	2.3	3.0	3.1	2.7	2.3	1.9	1.6

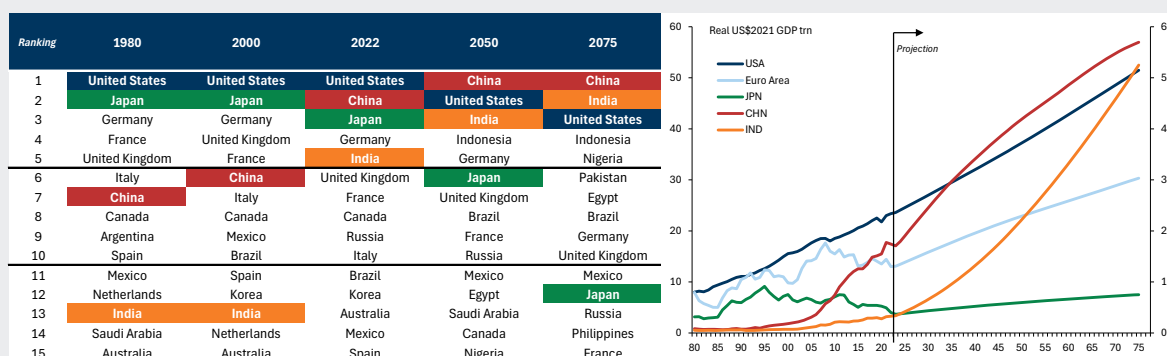
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 7 combines our GDP estimates with our long-term real exchange rate projections, to project the real US Dollar value of major economies over time.

In 2050, we project that the world's five largest economies will be China, the US, India, Indonesia, and Germany (with Indonesia displacing Brazil and Russia among the list of largest EMs over this horizon). We estimate that China will overtake the US as the world's largest economy around 2035.¹² If we extend the projection horizon to 2075, the world's three largest economies are China, India, and the US, with India (just) overtaking the US. Interestingly, US potential GDP growth is expected to be materially faster than China's at that horizon because of its better demographic outlook. Given the right policies and institutions, we project that current EMs will make up seven of the world's top ten economies in 2075.

Exhibit 7: Our Projections Imply that China, the US, India, Indonesia, and Germany Will be the World's Five Largest Economies in 2050

World's largest economies (measured in USD)



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

¹⁰ "The Path to 2075 — Slower Global Growth, But Convergence Remains Intact", Goldman Sachs Global

Making economic projections over a 50-year horizon for 104 countries inevitably involves a considerable degree of risk and uncertainty. Indeed, given the difficulties in forecasting even one or two years ahead, some readers may be skeptical of the value of forecasts that extend so far into the future. However, one advantage of making long-term projections is that cyclical risk – an important source of short-term forecasting error – tends to mean-revert over time, leaving GDP mostly determined by slower-moving trends in population, capital, and technology.

Economics Paper, 6 December 2022.

¹¹ Because of the large swings in GDP growth generated by the Covid pandemic, the 2024-29 column provides the cleanest indication of what our model indicates for near-term potential growth.

¹² Given the recent pessimism around China's long-term growth prospects, some readers may be surprised that we expect China to overtake the US at this horizon. However, three points are worth bearing in mind in this regard: First, China has already closed most of the gap with US GDP (China's GDP has risen from 12% of the US in 2000 to around 80% currently, measured in market exchange rates). Second, despite significant downward revisions, potential growth in China remains significantly higher than in the US on our revised estimates (4.0% vs. 1.9% for 2024-29). Third, in addition to differences in potential growth, we expect some of the US Dollar's real overvaluation vs. the Chinese Yuan to be unwound over the next 10-15 years.

Box 2: Comparing Our Results Across Different Growth Databases

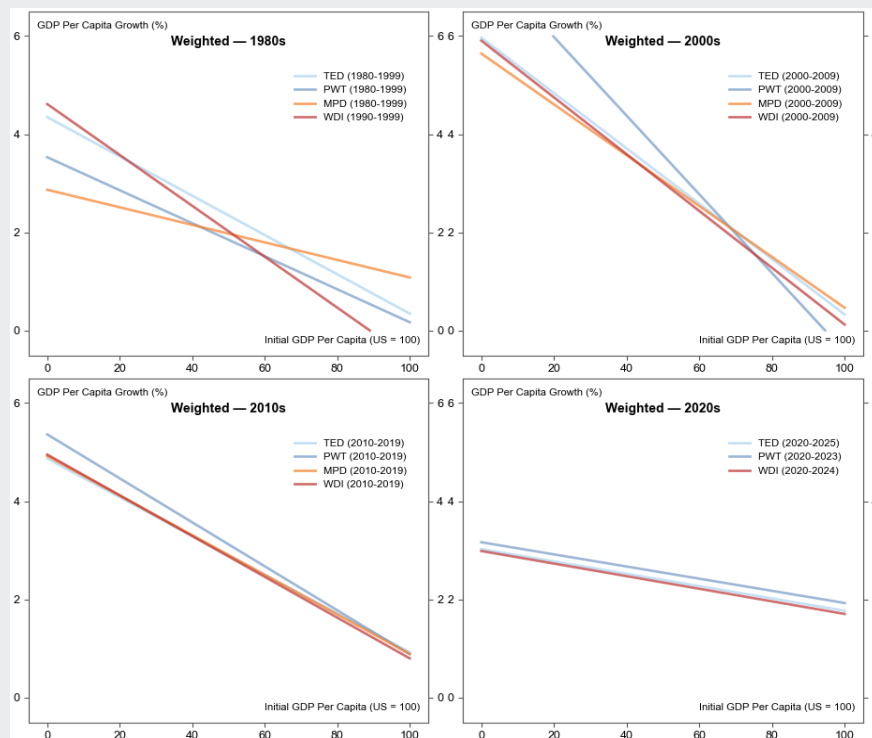
Growth and convergence studies typically use one of four different databases when analyzing long-term economic performance: World Development Indicators (WDI) by the World Bank, the Penn World Tables (PWT), the Maddison Project Database (MPD), and the Total Economy Database (TED) developed by the Conference Board. We generally use the Total Economy Database, partly because it provides the most up-to-date GDP figures. However, to cross-check our findings, we have replicated our analysis using each of these databases to ensure the robustness of our results.

Each of these databases possesses distinct advantages and limitations, making some more suitable than others depending on the research objectives. Among them, the Maddison database offers the most extensive historical coverage, in some cases reaching back centuries, making it ideal for studies in economic history. The World Bank's database has the shortest historical span, beginning only in 1990. Another key distinction is how they adjust GDP figures for differences in Purchasing Power Parity (PPP), which in turn impacts growth indicators.

The results of replicating our convergence analysis across each of the databases are presented in Exhibit 8. Although there are minor variations in the slopes of the fitted lines, the principal result—that weighted convergence persists—remains broadly consistent across all datasets.

Exhibit 8: Our Results Are Similar Across Each of the Main Growth Databases

Fitted lines - weighted by population, across the decades



Source: The Conference Board Total Economy Database™ (April 2026), Maddison Project Database (2020), Penn World Table 11.0, World Bank World Development Indicators, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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EUROPEAN ECONOMICS ANALYST

Spain – Structural Resilience Beyond the Energy Shock

- Although the energy shock is taking its toll on the Spanish economy, we still expect economic growth to outperform the rest of the Euro area. With growth running strongly above trend and the primary fiscal balance at the highest level since 2007, Spanish sovereign spreads are well-supported, relatively tight and resilient.
- The fiscal mix in Spain differs from other EMU4 countries. The government has decided not to prioritise defence spending and, even though the Spanish economy is less exposed to the conflict in the Middle East given its lower energy intensity, its fiscal response to the surge in energy prices is the most aggressive within the EMU4.
- Strong job growth has coincided with strong immigration and a shift in the workforce towards higher value-added service sectors—especially professional services, finance, and information technology—continuing to signal structural progress in the Spanish economy. Since 2021, Spain has recorded the highest productivity growth, per employee and per hour, within the EMU4.
- Investment growth remains resilient and broad-based. Spain's total capital expenditure is back to the level before the sovereign debt crisis and investment as a percent of GDP is set to overtake the Euro area, US and UK in 2026. The composition of the investment recovery also looks promising. The construction sector has consolidated its growth momentum and the surge in residential real estate prices due to net migration should attract additional investment in the sector. The key support from the European Recovery Fund comes to an end this year. However, we estimate that its effect will extend further.
- Against this macro backdrop, investors are constructive on Spanish government bonds. Our analysis finds no pricing of domestic risk: Spanish sovereign spreads have widened only in combination with flatter yield curves across Europe, pointing to rising inflation and slowing global growth as the sole factors responsible for the recent widening.
- We see two main risks that could potentially challenge this constructive outlook. As we move into the Summer, we estimate that an unresolved energy crisis feeding into air travel costs could lower GDP by 0.3% for every 10% reduction in tourist arrivals by air. Looking ahead to the 2027 election, any shift in opinion polls pointing to another split parliament or an increased likelihood of a minority

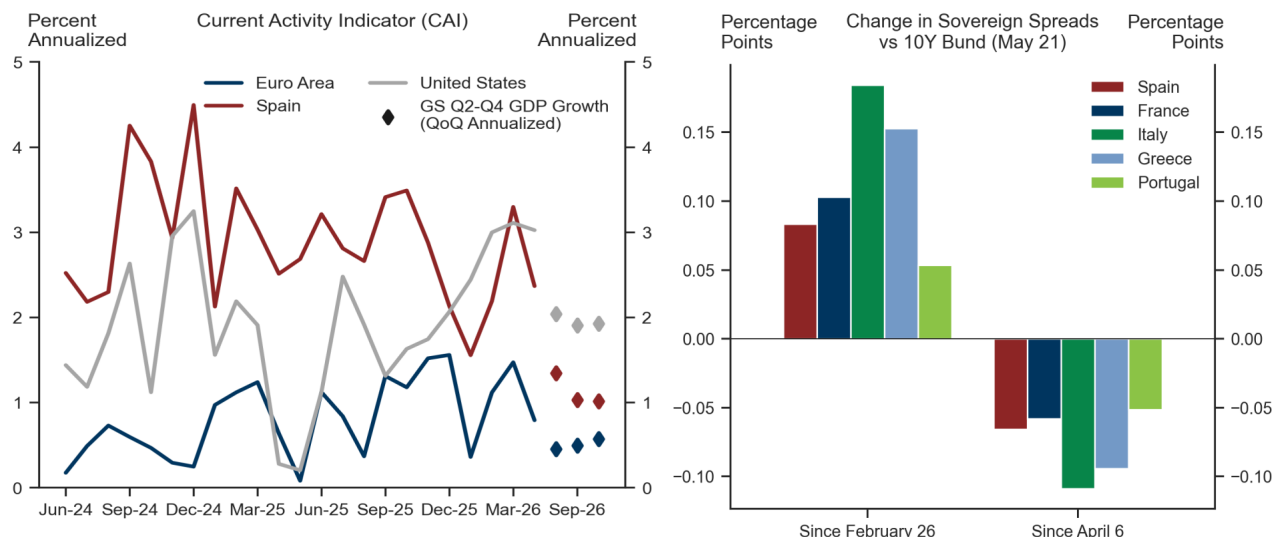
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government would reduce investors' confidence in extended gains on the economic front.

Spain – Structural Resilience Beyond the Energy Shock

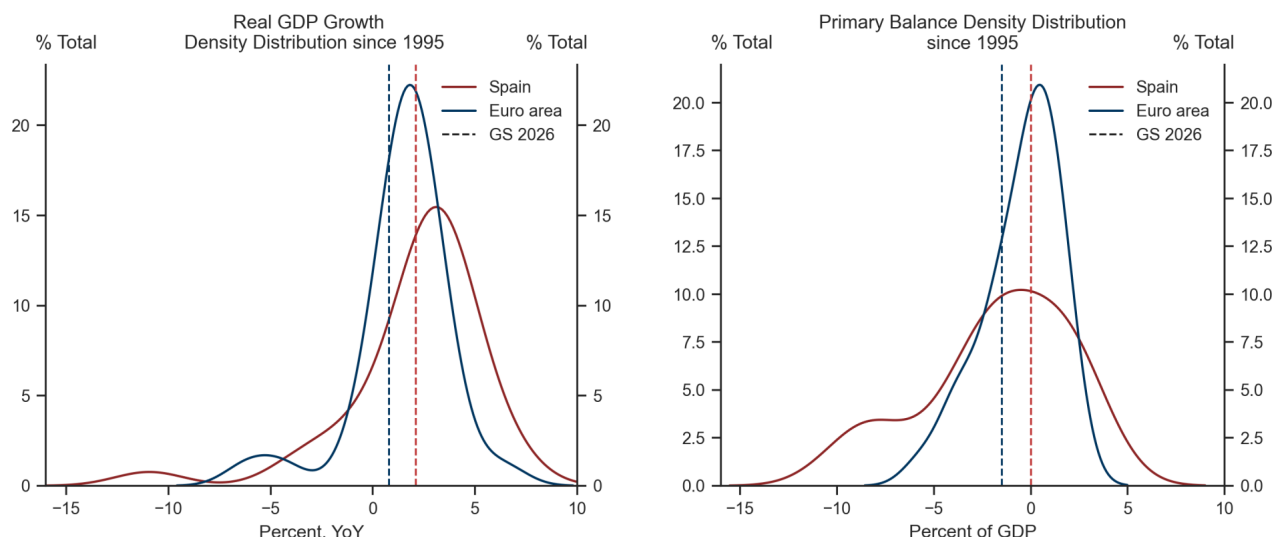
Spain's macro outperformance remains visible both in economic activity and in sovereign debt pricing. Economic activity has continued to run ahead of the Euro area and the US since the middle of last year, while sovereign spreads have remained comparatively tight, indicating investors' confidence in the outlook for Spain. That said, the Spanish economy is set to slow down because of the energy shock, although it is still outperforming the Euro area (Exhibit 1).

Exhibit 1: Growth Outperformance Keeps Spreads Tight



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

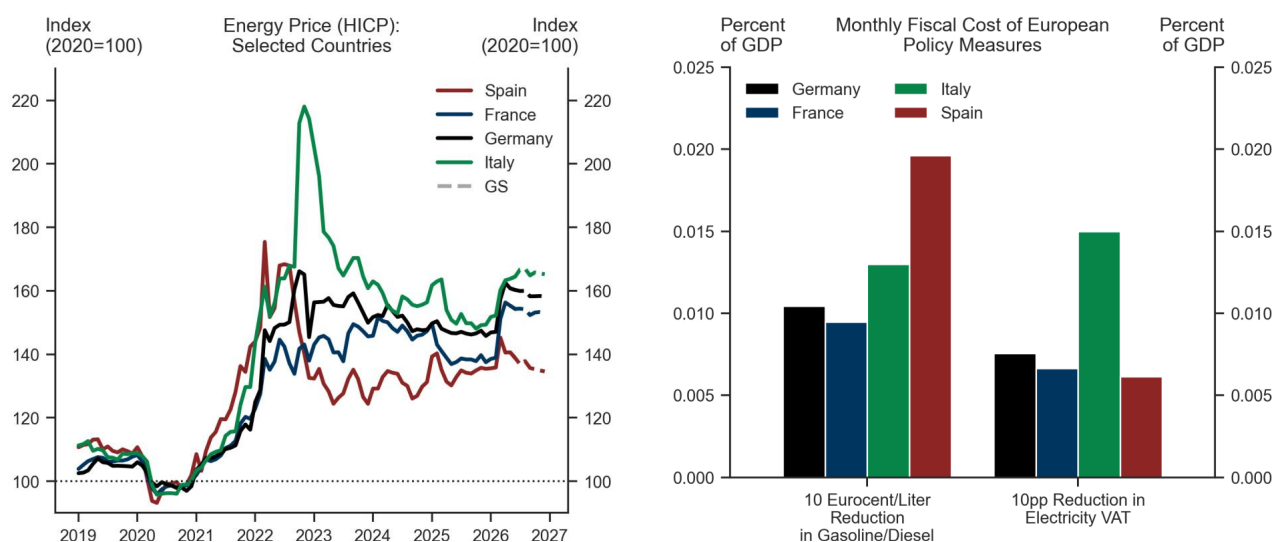
Current macroeconomic performance compares favourably from an historical standpoint. Spain entered this energy crisis from a relatively robust macro position. Even accounting for the upcoming slowdown, we forecast real GDP growth in 2026 at or above the long-run average, while the primary fiscal balance compares favourably with historical precedents and is the third-highest in the last 19 years (Exhibit 2).

Exhibit 2: Primary Balance and Real Growth are Close or Above the Historical Average

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

A Relatively Strong Fiscal Response to the Energy Crisis Leaves the Fiscal Balance in a Good Place

Spain's lower energy intensity helps contain the direct hit to growth, while fiscal risks remain manageable despite a relatively significant policy response. Since the 2022 energy crisis, Spain has been the least exposed in the EMU4 to the surge in energy prices. The fiscal cost of the most common measures used to shield consumers also sit at the lower end of the distribution in Spain, with the notable exception of tax cuts for petrol and diesel (Exhibit 3).

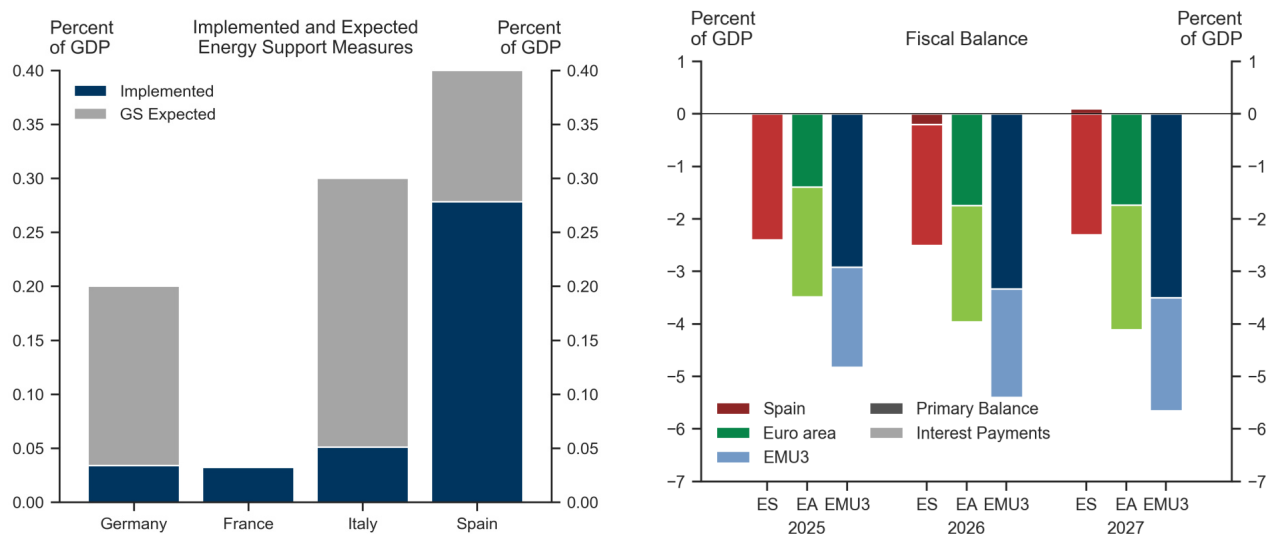
Exhibit 3: Lower Energy Exposure, Limited Fiscal Risk

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

However, Spain has delivered one of the most forceful energy-related fiscal responses in the region. Its decision not to prioritise defence spending and its relative insulation from the shock has allowed policymakers to provide support without materially undermining the broader fiscal position. While the increase in support has been the largest in the

EMU4, the fiscal balance remains among the most constructive in the Euro area. Spain's policy mix has been relatively expansionary, but it has not damaged its credibility from a sovereign perspective as Spain remains the only EMU4 country where we expect the debt-to-GDP ratio to be lower over the next three years (Exhibit 4).

Exhibit 4: Larger Energy Support, Strong Fiscal Position

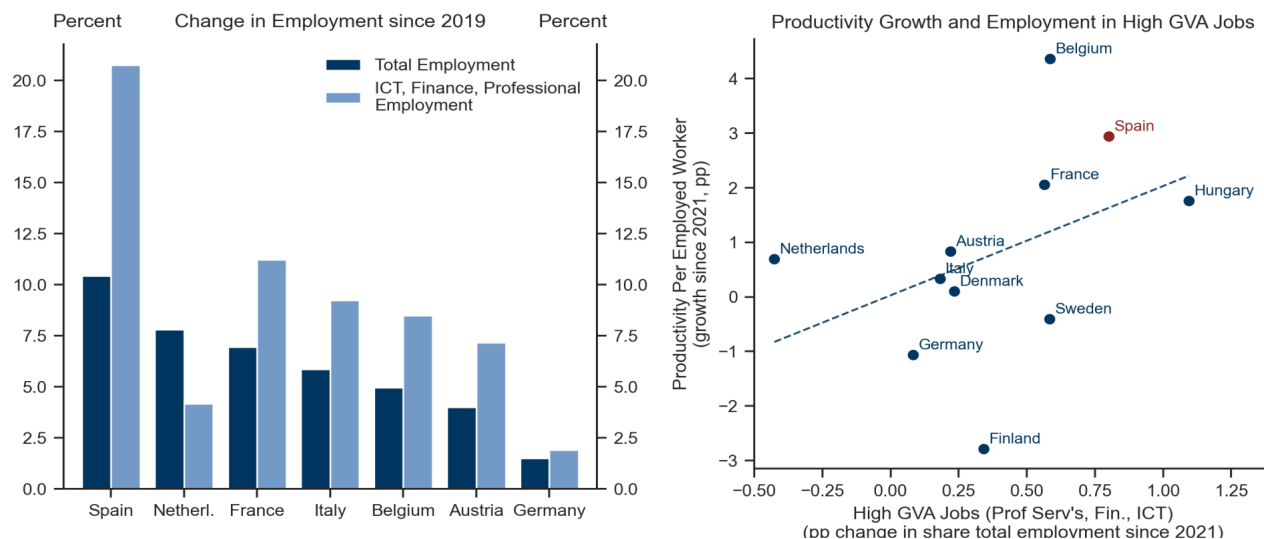


EMU3 includes Germany, France and Italy.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bruegel

Continuing Evidence of Structural Productivity Improvements

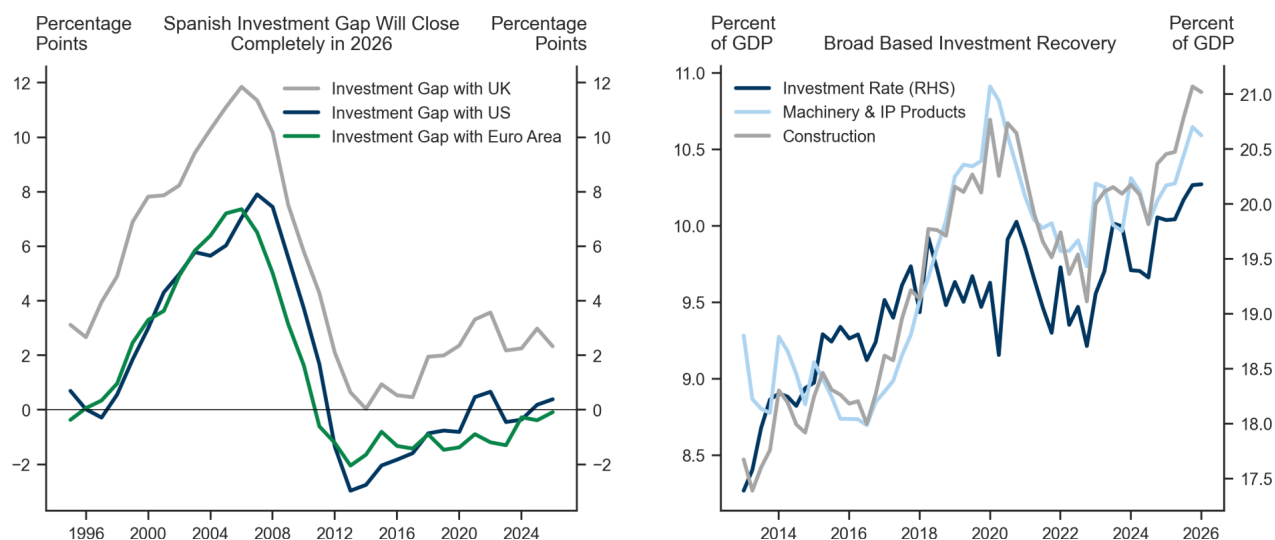
The employment rate is the highest it has ever been and the unemployment rate is the lowest since 2008. The Spanish labour market remains cyclically stable, accommodating large net migration flows, and employment gains have increasingly been concentrated in higher-value-added service sectors (professional services, finance and ICT). This job reallocation, a specific feature of the Spanish economy in the European landscape, appears to be feeding through into stronger productivity performance. Spain's recent outperformance likely reflects a gradual improvement in the quality—not only the quantity—of labour demand (Exhibit 5).

Exhibit 5: Labour Reallocation Supports Productivity

GVA stands for Gross Value Added.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

Capital accumulation has also been an engine for growth. The investment recovery in Spain is both resilient and broad. Capital expenditure has regained ground relative to past cycles and is set to close the investment gap with the Euro area, US and UK this year. The composition of the investment recovery looks especially promising, with capital expenditure on machinery and intellectual property products the highest in 25 years. A durable investment momentum is typically associated with an extended expansion (Exhibit 6).

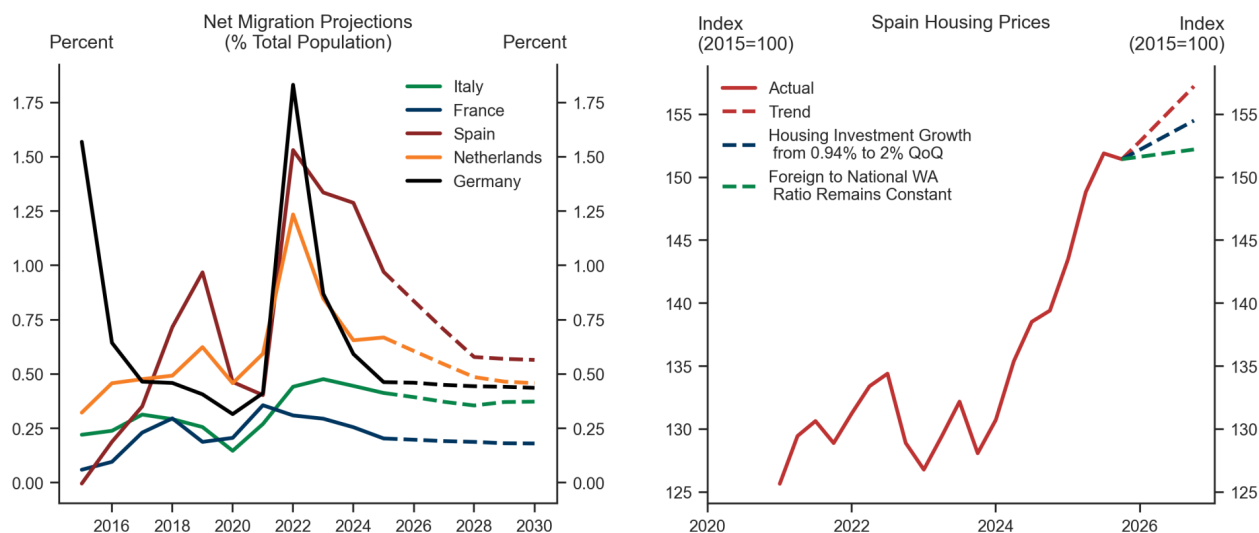
Exhibit 6: Investment Recovery Gains Traction

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

The construction sector has consolidated its growth momentum. Net migration into Spain in particular has been elevated since 2023 and a key factor supporting economic growth. But demographic pressure has also tightened the housing market, raising sharply residential real estate prices by almost 20% over the last two years. While house prices have risen, supply has struggled to keep pace and we estimate that housing

investment needs to double in order to normalize residential real estate appreciation. We expect this factor, along with the surge in residential real estate prices due to net migration, to attract additional investment in the sector (Exhibit 7).

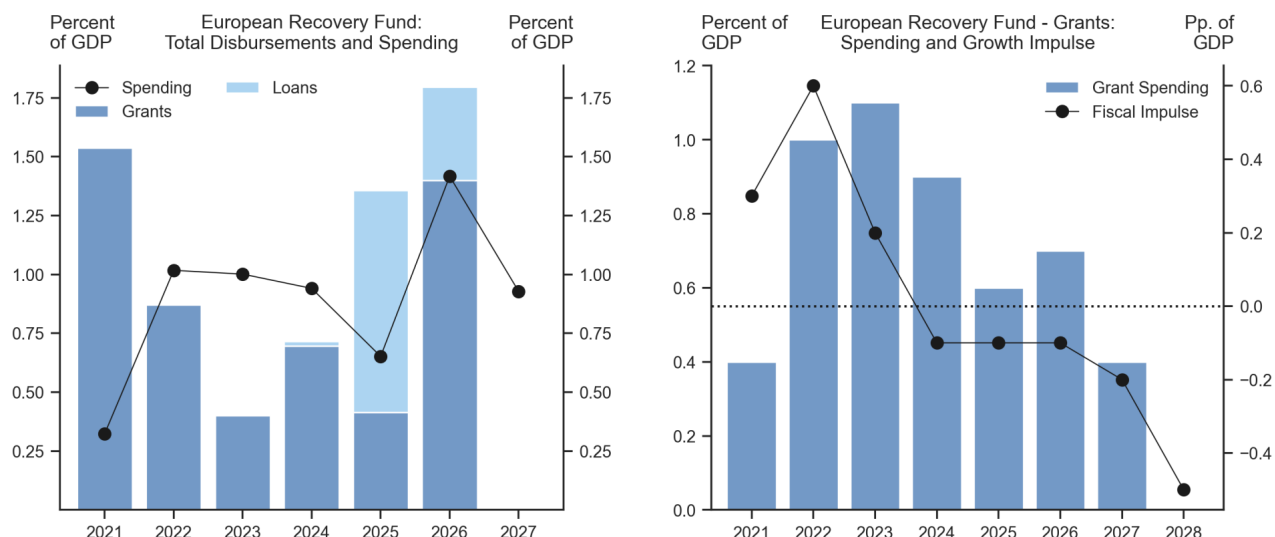
Exhibit 7: Net Migration and Demographics Lift Housing Prices



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

The government has also set up a specific policy tool to support developments in the housing sector. By establishing the *España crece* (Spain Grows) fund, the government plans to mobilise EUR 60bn through the Official Credit Institute (ICO) to reach a total investment of around EUR 120 billion (9% of GDP), combining public and private capital. Endowed with a capital injection of EUR10.5bn from the European Recovery Plan, the fund explicitly targets private leverage to augment investment in residential developments.

The fund was also part of a broader strategy of the Spanish government to extend the impact of the European Recovery Fund beyond the end of the programme in 2026. The Recovery Fund has been a key factor supporting investment growth and comes to an end this year. Since a large share of investment projects will only be completed in the first half of next year and with the *España crece* fund in place, we estimate that the support of the European Recovery Fund will extend beyond the end of 2026, suggesting a moderation rather than collapse of fiscal support for investment, and reducing the risk of an abrupt halt in capex momentum (Exhibit 8).

Exhibit 8: Recovery Fund Support Fades Gradually

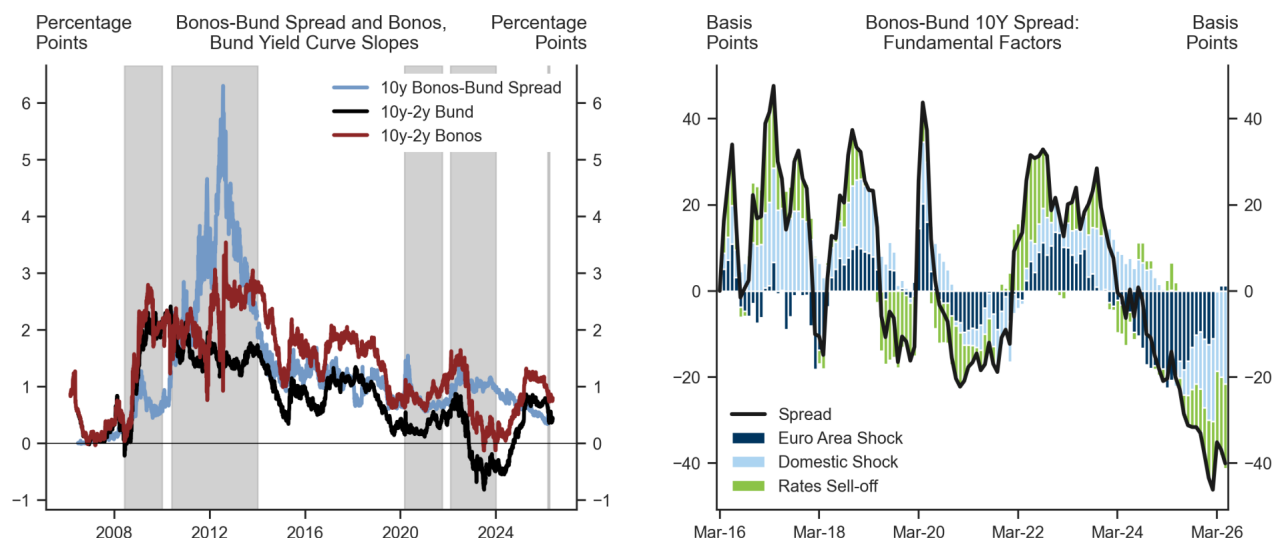
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

A Constructive Outlook for Spanish Debt

Investors are constructive on Spanish bonds as weakening momentum due to the energy crisis seems to have been unaffected by country-specific risks. In line with [previous work](#), we use a simple structural vector autoregression (SVAR) model with “sign restrictions” to disentangle the underlying macro drivers of sovereign debt pricing. To do so, we define the drivers as follows:

1. Euro Area Shock: when both the Spanish and German sovereign yield curve flatten (10y-2y Bonos and 10y-2y Bund) and the Spanish sovereign spread (10y Bonos-Bund) widens.
2. Domestic Shock: when only the Spanish sovereign yield curve flattens and the Spanish sovereign spread widens at the same time.
3. Long-End Rates Sell-off: when both the Spanish and German sovereign yield curves steepen and the Spanish sovereign spread widens.

In this simple way, it is possible to assess whether the market pricing of Spanish sovereign spreads is more likely to be due to external macro factors – e.g., a deteriorated growth outlook or inflation surging in the region, with rates selling off – or to risk factors specific to the Spanish landscape that push up the yield curve and widen the sovereign spread at the same time. We find that domestic risk (a flatter Spanish curve and wider spread) has remained contained throughout the energy shock so far, while spread widening has been combined with flatter yield curves across Europe. This points to rising inflation and growth concerns beyond the idiosyncratic risks for the Spanish economy and is consistent with the view that investors are currently attaching a negligible Spain-specific risk premium (Exhibit 9).

Exhibit 9: Spreads Price European, Not Domestic, Risk

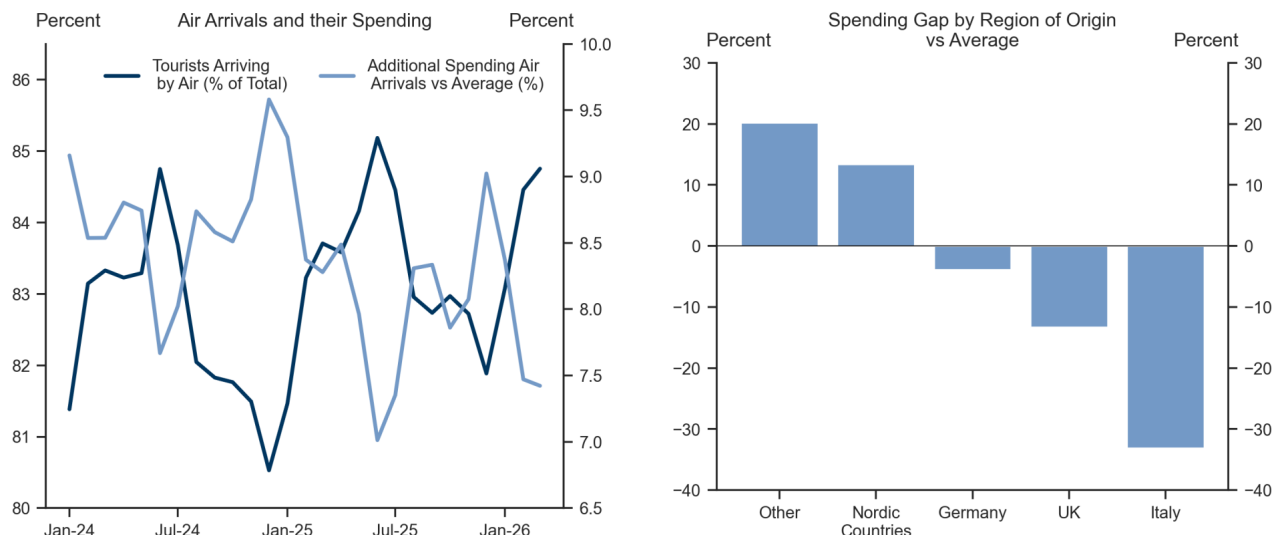
The sovereign spread depicted in the right chart shows the deviation of the spread from the sample average.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

Two Risks To Watch: Energy Hit on the Tourism Sector and Prolonged Political Uncertainty

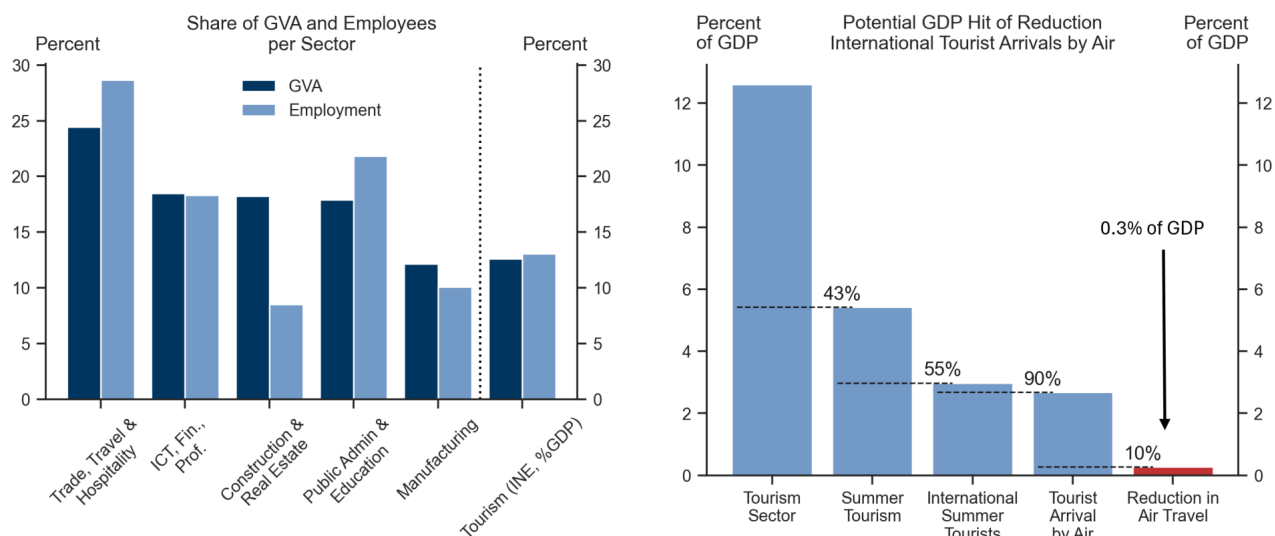
We see two main risks that could potentially derail the otherwise constructive outlook for the Spanish economy.

The first is the potential impact of the energy crisis on the tourism sector in Spain specifically, and Southern Europe more broadly. As the Summer approaches, an unresolved energy crisis could feed into air travel costs. Tourist arrivals by air matter disproportionately for Spain's growth outlook. They not only represent almost 90% of total international tourist arrivals in Spain but they also display a higher propensity to spend. An energy-driven increase in travel costs would not only reduce arrivals, but could also weigh more heavily on the highest-value segment of external demand (Exhibit 10).

Exhibit 10: Air Travel Brings Higher-Spending Tourists

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

The size of the tourism sector is not easy to measure because of the multiple spillovers in related sectors, such as trade and cultural services. However, available estimates place the sector in the range of 10-15% of Spanish GDP. The National Statistical Institute (INE) estimates that tourism contributes 12.6% of GDP. With this magnitude in mind, and taking into account the relevance of the summer season (June–September) and the share of international tourist arrivals by air in total spending, we find that every 10% reduction in tourist arrivals by air could lower GDP by about 0.3% (Exhibit 11).

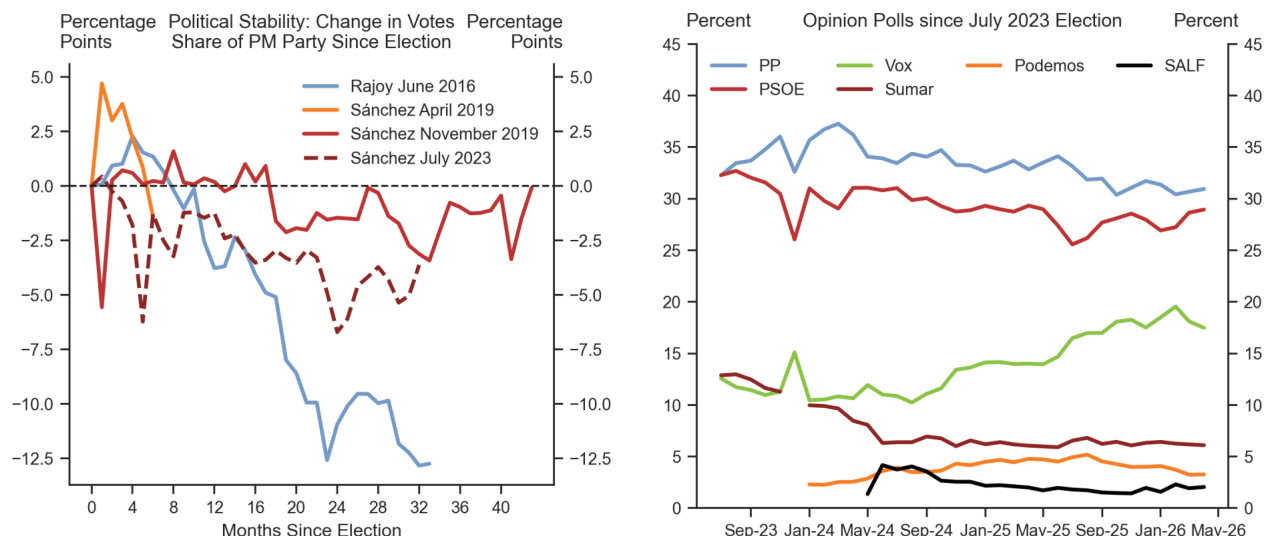
Exhibit 11: Tourism is Large Share Spanish GDP and Tourist Arrivals by Air is Key Component

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, INE, Haver Analytics

The second risk for the Spanish outlook is prolonged political uncertainty. PM Sanchez has been in office since 2018, but since the 2023 snap election he has led a minority government unable to approve a fully fledged annual budget. This limited ability to shape fiscal policy has not impeded the reduction of Spain's fiscal deficit, but the support of the European Recovery Fund has been key in securing investment growth despite political fragmentation.

With the European programme coming to an end this year, the need for a government able to approve the annual budget will become more urgent. Current opinion polls suggest a steady shift in support from PM Sanchez's centre-left party (PSOE) to the alternative centre-right and fiscally conservative People's Party (PP), although they also point to a non-negligible likelihood that the 2027 election will deliver another divided parliament unable to form a clear and stable majority (Exhibit 12).

Exhibit 12: Polls Point to Likely Change of Ruling Coalition in 2027, But Risk of Political Fragmentation Remains



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Politico

Looking ahead to the 2027 election, investors are likely to focus on the likelihood of another parliament without a clear majority and the possibility of a minority government. Prolonged political uncertainty would likely reduce investors' confidence in the continuing transformation of the Spanish economy and weaken the case for our constructive outlook.

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